

That's not a lot, but it ought to be worth something besides a Christmas card and the firm's latest ideas. Remember, it only takes a broker about four seconds to fill out a buy or sell order, and another fifteen seconds to walk it to the order desk. Sometimes this job is handled by a courier or a runner.

Why is it that people who wouldn't dream of paying for gas at the full-service pump without getting the oil checked and the windows washed demand nothing from the full-service broker? Well, maybe they call him or her a couple of times a week to ask "How are my stocks doing?" or "How good is this market?"—but figuring the up-to-the-minute value of a portfolio doesn't count as investment research. I realize the broker may also serve as a parental figure, market forecaster, and human tranquilizer during unfavorable price swings. None of this actually helps you pick good companies.

Even as far back as the early nineteenth century, the poet Shelley found stockbrokers (or at least one of them) eager to lend a helping hand to their clients. "Is it not odd that the only generous person I ever knew, who had money to be generous with, should be a stockbroker?" Today's brokers may be less likely to send large, unsolicited donations to their clients, but as information gatherers they can be the stockpicker's best friend. They can provide the S&P reports and the investment newsletters, the annuals, quarterlies and prospectuses and proxy statements, the *Value Line* survey and the research from the firm's analysts. Let them get the data on p/e ratios and growth rates, on insider buying and ownership by institutions. They'll be happy to do it, once they realize that you're serious.

If you use the broker as an advisor (a foolhardy practice generally, but sometimes worthwhile), then ask the broker to give you the two-minute speech on the recommended stocks. You'll probably have to prompt the broker with some of the questions I've listed before, and a typical dialogue that now goes—

BROKER: "We're recommending Zayre. It's a special situation."

YOU: "Do you really think it's good?"

BROKER: "We really think it's good."

YOU: "Great. I'll buy it."

—would be transformed into something like this:

BROKER: "We're recommending La Quinta Motor Inns. It just made our buy list."

YOU: "How would you classify this stock? Cyclical, slow grower, faster grower, or what?"